

End user Consensus on Effective and Feasible Heat Stress Mitigation Strategies: A Delphi Study

Background: Occupational heat exposure is becoming an ever-pressing issue. It can adversely affect the heat, safety and capacity of workers, yet there is limited evidence into the application of heat-mitigation and recovery strategies in Australian workplaces. Furthermore, little is known as to which strategies end users believe are effective, feasible and acceptable for supporting recovery and resilience between consecutive days of physically challenging work in the heat.

Aim: This study aims to establish consensus and priority of post-shift recovery strategies for further evaluation in applied Australian occupational settings.

Methods: A modified Delphi study will be conducted with Australian end users who have direct experience with working in, managing workers in and developing policy for physically demanding work in the heat. Candidate strategies have been identified through a scoping review and refined by an expert panel consultation. These candidate strategies will be presented across two Delphi rounds. Participants will rate their agreement across effectiveness, feasibility and acceptability for each statement with predefined criteria set to determine consensus and prioritisation.

Expected outcomes: This study will identify and establish priority of post-shift strategies that end users consider effective and implementable in occupational settings. Findings will also inform the design and testings of subsequent efficacy testings within the REFRESH program as well as contributing to evidence informed occupational heat management.